

The Nile

The longest river on Earth, running from central Africa to the Mediterranean, and a lifeline for millions of people on its route



The longest river in the world, the Nile flows more than 4,130 miles (6,650 km), from its source near the equator, through East and northeast Africa to its mouth on the Mediterranean Sea. The Nile basin drains more than 1 million square miles (3 million square km)—about 10 percent of Africa's land area.

White and Blue

The Nile has two major tributaries. Considered the river's primary stream, the White Nile flows from the north of Lake Victoria (see p.196), in Uganda, and descends into the Great Rift Valley (see pp.184–87) over the Murchison Falls. After crossing Lake Albert, it passes onto the huge wetland plain of the Sudd. At Khartoum, Sudan, it is met by the Blue Nile, which has its source at Lake Tana in the Ethiopian Highlands. From here, the Nile runs over a series of cataracts, or rapids, before passing through Egypt's historic valleys. North of Cairo, the river splits into two branches—the Rosetta to the west and the Damietta to the east—forming the Nile Delta as it enters the Mediterranean.

▽ MISTY FALLS

The Blue Nile Falls, in Ethiopia, is known locally as Tis Abay, meaning "great smoke." Spanning up to 1,300 ft (400 m) in the rainy season, its waters plunge 150 ft (45 m) to the bottom.

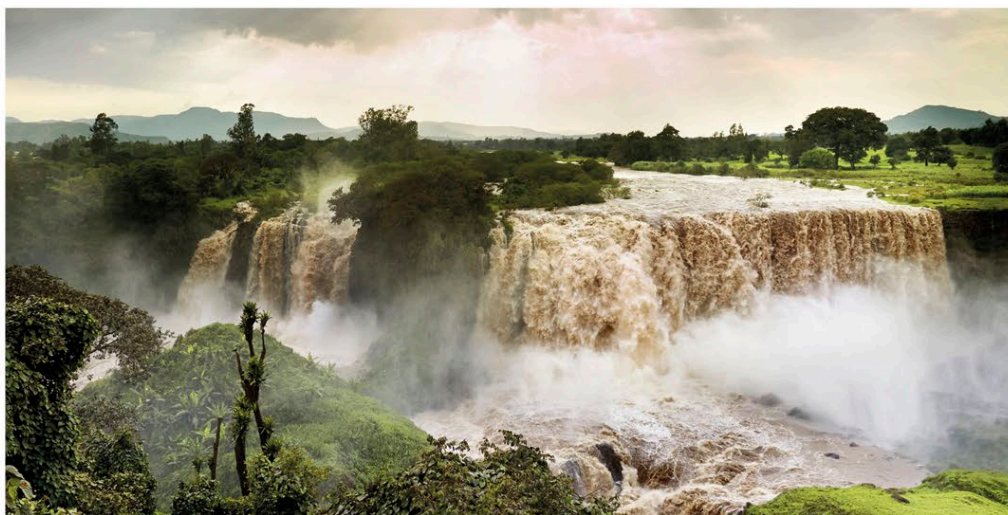
Welcome floods

The Nile Delta, one of the most populated and highly cultivated parts of Egypt, was originally formed of sediment brought down by the Blue Nile from the Ethiopian Plateau. Indeed, the flooding of the Nile has been an important annual cycle, delivering not only water but also fertile silt that replenishes the soil across the floodplain. However, since the completion of the Aswan High Dam in 1970, the flow of the Nile has been significantly moderated, and traditional farming practices have been greatly affected.



△ SOLITARY FORAGER

The shoebill is a large, storklike bird that typically forages alone for fish, which it snaps up with its huge, hook-tipped bill.



It takes **three months** for the **water leaving Lake Victoria** to reach the **Mediterranean**